

Quality Assurance / Performance Improvement (QAPI)

Ongoing Monitoring and Improvement of Care Quality

Regulation: 42 CFR §482.21

POLICY OVERVIEW

QAPI integrates quality assurance (QA) and performance improvement (PI) into a comprehensive, data-driven program that continuously improves patient safety, quality of care, and organizational performance. The program must be hospital-wide and involve all departments and services.

KEY REQUIREMENTS

1 Program Design & Scope

The QAPI program must address: patient safety, medical errors/near misses, utilization of services, patient outcomes, patient and family experience, care transitions, and regulatory compliance. The scope must encompass all departments, services, and settings of care.

2 Data Collection & Analysis

Performance data must be systematically collected and analyzed using valid statistical methods. Measures must include: process measures, outcome measures, and patient experience measures. Data must be compared to national benchmarks.

3 Performance Improvement Projects

Focused improvement projects must be conducted when data identifies significant performance gaps. Projects must use a structured improvement methodology (PDSA, Lean, Six Sigma) and be data-driven throughout.

4 Adverse Events & Root Cause Analysis

All serious adverse events, sentinel events, and never events must be analyzed through root cause analysis (RCA). Action plans must address root causes, and effectiveness must be monitored. Near-misses should also be analyzed for system improvement.

5 Governing Body Reporting

QAPI program results, including performance trends, improvement project outcomes, and adverse events, must be reported to the Governing Body at least quarterly. The Governing Body must provide oversight and allocate resources for improvement.

COMPLIANCE NOTES

The Medical Staff and Nursing Leadership must be actively engaged in QAPI. Quality data must be used in credentialing and privileging decisions. The QAPI program must be evaluated annually for effectiveness and updated accordingly.

COMMON SURVEY CITATIONS

Cited under §482.21(a) – Program scope, §482.21(b) – Program data and activities, §482.21(c) – Program activities, and §482.21(e) – Governing body responsibilities.